Building High-Performing Teams - Study guide

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About this guide

Design the rhythms, roles and culture that let teams of teams perform and stay well.

These notes follow the video lecture for this course. Read them before or after watching, and use them to revise before the final quiz.

What you will be able to do

- Diagnose what is holding a team back

- Design team rituals that stick

- Align several teams around shared goals

What holds teams back

- Performance has causes you can find

- Most issues are trust, clarity or energy

- Diagnose before you fix

Welcome to Building High-Performing Teams. When a team underperforms, leaders often reach for a fix straight away, such as a new process or a team day out. But the cause may be something else. This lecture is about diagnosing first. Most team problems fall under trust, clarity or energy. Once you know which, the right action becomes obvious. We will cover how to run a quick team health check, how to design rituals that stick, and how to align several teams around shared goals, so that groups of teams work together instead of against each other.

Diagnosing a team

- Trust: do people speak openly

- Clarity: do they know goals and roles

- Energy: do they feel able to do good work

A quick diagnosis looks at three areas. Trust, which asks whether people speak openly and rely on each other. Clarity, which asks whether people know the goals, the roles and what good looks like. And energy, which asks whether people feel able to do good

work, or whether they are stretched and tired. Ask short questions on each, using a simple scale. Do it anonymously, so that people are honest. The scores will not give you the full story, but they show where to look and where to start the conversation.

Sharing results without blame

- Share the scores openly

- Ask what stands out to the team

- Choose one thing to work on

Sharing the results is where many leaders go wrong. If the data feels like a judgement, people become defensive. Present the scores as information about the team, not about individuals. Ask the team what stands out to them, and what they would add. Listen more than you talk. Then choose one thing to work on, not five. A single, shared priority is more likely to move than a long list. Agree who will lead it and when you will review progress. The process of looking together often improves trust by itself.

Rituals that stick

- Small, regular and visible

- Tied to something that already happens

- Owned by the team, not only the leader

Most team agreements fade by Wednesday. Rituals help them last. A ritual is a small, regular action that the team does together, such as a short start of week check in, a Friday round of thanks, or a monthly look at what to stop doing. The best rituals are small, regular and visible. Tie them to something that already happens, such as an existing meeting. And make them owned by the team, so that they continue when the leader is away. Start with one ritual, and keep it going for two months before adding another.

Designing a good ritual

- Decide the purpose in one sentence

- Keep it under fifteen minutes

- Review whether it is still useful

To design a ritual, begin with the purpose in one sentence. For example, to make sure everyone knows the priorities for the week. Keep it under fifteen minutes, since long rituals get skipped. Rotate who leads it, so that the ownership is shared. And review every couple of months whether it is still useful. Drop it if not, because a ritual that has lost its point is worse than none. The aim is a small number of habits that people value, not a calendar full of obligations.

Teams of teams

- Shared goals across teams

- Clear interfaces between teams

- Leaders who connect rather than control

When several teams need to work together, new problems appear. Each team may optimise for its own goals, while the overall result suffers. To scale well, give the teams shared goals that they can all see. Make the interfaces between teams clear, meaning what each team provides to the others, and how to ask for it. And lead by connecting rather than controlling. Bring team leads together regularly, so that they hear each other's challenges. When teams understand each other's work, handovers improve, and conflict falls.

Handling dependencies and handovers

- Name dependencies early

- Agree what a good handover looks like

- Fix problems at the source

Many delays in larger organisations come from dependencies between teams. Name them early, in planning, rather than discovering them late. Agree what a good handover looks like, including what information is passed on and in what form. When something goes wrong, look for the cause at the source, rather than blaming the team where the problem showed up. A short regular meeting between teams that rely on each other can prevent months of friction. These are practical steps, but they make teams of teams

feel like one organisation.

Your next steps

- Run a three-question health check

- Start one ritual for two months

- Complete the workbook and the final quiz

To finish, run the three question health check with your team this month, and share the results openly. Choose one ritual to start, and commit to it for two months. Complete the workbook for this course, which has the health check form and a ritual design page. Then take the final quiz. When you reach the end of the last lesson you will receive your certificate and a personal review of how you worked through the course. High performance is built from steady habits, so begin with one and build from there.

Glossary

Team health check: A short anonymous survey of trust, clarity and energy.

Ritual: A small, regular, visible team action that keeps an agreement alive.

Dependency: A piece of work that one team needs from another before it can proceed.

Interface: The agreed way one team requests and receives work from another.